

The Beast of En
By Malin Janna Vega

It was the third time today that Jorge had made a fool of himself. The first was when the King assigned him to mop up horse droppings in the royal stable. The second when his horse (who's droppings he'd just mopped hours beforehand) bucked him off its back and left him in the dirt, his bottom wet and soiled. At the moment, he was watching in despair as a girl in a green dress swallowed the one thing he wanted the most without even a bite or a smack.

Earlier this week, the King's daughter fell ill. A hefty reward was offered to the man who found the cure to her condition—apparently it was fatal. This announcement had swept through the kingdom like a flood, clouding the minds of every capable man. One of these men was Jorge, and he was a ranger. As posters were pasted on grimy brick walls and gossip was whispered by the town wives and servants, Jorge caught a whiff of a rumor: that a rare, magical flower that cures all ailments grew to the south of the kingdom, right on the outskirts of the King's domain.

Just minutes ago, he was riding steadily to the garden called En, the last of the Kingdom's preserved sanctuaries. This one was the farthest from the city, and wholly untouched. Unlike the other natural preserves that were run by gardeners and scientists, the Garden En did not have a border or keepers. When Jorge found himself there, he was entranced by the pixies and the hummingbirds for just a moment before his body was flying to the ground, and his horse was galloping away.

Drat. Jorge thought. He had nothing but a flask of water and rations enough for only three days. A rabbit suddenly hopped by and paused to stare at the ranger with its deep black eyes before bounding away. Jorge shivered at the prospect of killing it. As if through divine manifestation, his wandering eye caught sight of a lavender flower that shone apart from all the colorful wildlife that surrounded it.

Jorge sighed in relief. He'd be able to start trekking back home soon, after all. He scrambled to his feet, jogging towards the flower. He had almost reached it before a pale hand uprooted the flower.

"Wait..." Jorge started, out of breath. His gaze traveled to the face of a young girl whose hair was so blond it almost matched her skin color. Before he could process what was happening, she promptly ate the flower.

The ranger only stared at her in shock before coming to his senses. "You're trespassing!" He spluttered, pointing a finger at the girl. "This garden is protected by the royal family, you can't be here."

The girl blinked at him with her big, green eyes and cocked her head. "This is my home."

Her calmness infuriated Jorge. "The King ordered me to retrieve that flower."

The girl reached into her mouth and pulled out the flower's stem. She then stuck it in the ground and patted the dirt around it. "Two more will grow back. If you don't believe me, come back tomorrow."

"You must be there as well, then."

"Of course." Then the girl left the same way she appeared.

Jorge was already starting a fire before he realized he'd let her trespass yet again.

The next day two flowers had sprouted where the original once was. Jorge grabbed one and pulled it out of the ground. He almost rejoiced, but it wilted within seconds. He decided to try again before his hand was swatted away by the same girl from yesterday.

“Hey!” Jorge protested.

“It seems the Garden does not favor you.”

“What nonsense are you spouting?”

“En has a mind of her own,” the girl said, gently pulling out the flower. Just like the day before, she ate it in one gulp before Jorge could stop her.

Jorge collapsed, defeated. “Why must you make things so difficult for me? I don’t have all week. I should just kill you now, I have every right to just put a dagger through your chest.”

“And yet you’re the one on the ground. Besides, the law doesn’t scare me... but do you know what *is* scary?”

“Starving to death in this cursed garden.”

“The Beast of En.”

Jorge sat up, his ranger instincts tingling. “There’s no beast in this garden. There are none anywhere in the Kingdom, even the realm! The knights and rangers such as myself drove them out decades ago. If even one came back, it would be news all over the city.”

“You’ve killed beasts?” The girl’s eyes suddenly lit up.

“Well, no,” Jorge blushed. “But I am a ranger.”

The girl’s face fell. “But you can still defeat one, no? Maybe you can help me kill the beast.”

“This *beast* doesn’t exist. I would know.”

“But clearly, you don’t.”

Jorge stormed off angrily, tired of the girl’s words. He would get those flowers, no matter what it took. Yet as he toiled in his camping tent eating watery sausage, he couldn’t let go of what she said.

The Garden En was home to faes, pixies, deers, foxes, and many more animals that came too close to Jorge’s campsite for his liking. He would sometimes hear crunches of branches behind the trees, or ruffling of bushes. But none of them were beasts.

“What do you even need flowers for anyway?” He asked the girl grumpily the next day, as she gobbled up the flower before he could take it. She always seemed to appear just as his goal was within reach, only to snatch it away.

“You corrupted the stem. Only one flower grew today.” The girl said.

“You didn’t answer my question.”

“I’ve been sick for a long time, just like your princess. These flowers make me feel a little better.”

“They don’t heal you instantly?” He asked, mystified.

“No, my condition is... special,” the girl admitted.

“Oh.”

The rest of the day, Jorge stayed sitting on the grass, staring at the place where the flowers would grow anew. Even when he blinked and the girl disappeared, he only looked sullenly to the ground, deep in thought.

Days passed, and Jorge still hadn't figured out how to gain the favor of the garden. Every time he'd try to pick up a flower, it would die within moments. His rations were long gone, and he resorted to foraging and hunting small animals for food. The water he got from the scattered falls and pools around the garden tasted heavenly. Everything seemed to be tranquil aside from the storm brewing in his head.

One day, the girl offered him a flower, for four had sprouted at once. Jorge's face lit up in glee as he took it into his hands and ran off. The ranger skulked back a few minutes later with wilted petals in hand.

"You mustn't disrespect the gifts of the garden," the girl said.

"It's not a gift from the garden. It's a gift from you."

"If someone gives you something, you must accept it with grace. That is what my elders taught me."

The next time he was given a flower, Jorge ate it with grace.

The pair were crossing a river, jumping from rock to rock. With every passing day, the girl would stick around with Jorge for longer.

"During patrols, I looked for paw marks on the dirt." Jorge said. "I found no beast-looking ones."

"It is real." The girl said indignantly. "It's tricky. It disguises itself as other animals, so when you do get eaten, it seems harmless and no one will suspect that the chicken tracks leading out of your tent are actually those of a *fearsome monster*!" She leapt at him, and the ranger jumped. The girl giggled. "I scared you!"

"You did not." Jorge muttered. "Fine, I'll play along. What does it even want?"

"I think it's greedy." The two were now settling on the soft grass, taking in the smell and the sounds of twittering birds. "Its poor, twisted soul likes when people are sick."

"Then why don't you just leave with your flowers and run?"

The girl sat up and placed a flower behind his ear and smiled. "Some things are worth a little risk."

The next day, Jorge found a new set of tracks. He crouched down on the ground, examining them. "Horses. Many horses," he concluded.

He ran, following the tracks. "It's not a beast at all! It's just the—" he stopped when he saw the King and his guards, all of them on horses. The King's horse's hoof was raised, getting ready to deal another blow to the already trampled, bleeding, blonde girl who was curled up on the ground, shaking. Jorge felt as if his world had stopped spinning.

The King turned his head and spotted the ranger. "Ah, good ranger," he said slowly, as if he'd been expecting Jorge. "Please remove this beast from my garden."